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The Change the NCAA Does Not Know It Needs: A Promotion/Relegation Structure for College Football

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Abstract

After each college football season, the talking heads debate which team missed out on the College Football Playoffs. Each year it is a different school who everyone says should have made the playoffs. There are a multitude of reasons for or against each team every year, but the main point remains that the NCAA will always have this problem on their hands. This article proposes the solution of a promotion/relegation style structure which will completely change the dynamic of the conference layout. It will give an opportunity to the best teams outside of the 'Power 5' or FBS to make the College Football Playoffs. There may be many questions still needed to be answered if this format is adopted, but this article provides the building blocks. The NCAA has a chance to build more passionate fan bases while breaking out of its mold by trying something new and exciting. Under this system, anything can happen.

THE CHANGE THE NCAA DOES NOT KNOW IT NEEDS: A PROMOTION/RELEGATION STRUCTURE FOR COLLEGE FOOTBALL

*By: Jack Noonan**

ABSTRACT

After each college football season, the talking heads debate which team missed out on the College Football Playoffs. Each year it is a different school who everyone says should have made the playoffs. There are a multitude of reasons for or against each team every year, but the main point remains that the NCAA will always have this problem on their hands.

This article proposes the solution of a promotion/relegation style structure which will completely change the dynamic of the conference layout. It will give an opportunity to the best teams outside of the 'Power 5' or FBS to make the College Football Playoffs. There may be many questions still needed to be answered if this format is adopted, but this article provides the building blocks. The NCAA has a chance to build more passionate fan bases while breaking out of its mold by trying something new and exciting. Under this system, anything can happen.

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I. INTRODUCTION

At the end of the college football season each year, the national media and talking pundits across the country argue about the one team that did not have a chance to make it to the College Football Playoffs.¹ In 2017, it was the University of Central Florida (UCF) who went undefeated;² the year before, it was Western Michigan who only lost once;³ and in earlier years, before the playoff format, it was Boise State who always had people clamoring that they should have a chance to play in the National Championship.⁴ Each year it is a different school, and each year it is the same conversation.⁵

One reason these schools are disregarded is that they are not in a “Power Five” conference.⁶ The classification of “Power Five” conference is in relation to the status of the top five conferences that seem to be the dominant conferences in the NCAA.⁷ These five are: the Atlantic Coast Conference (ACC), the Big Ten, the Big 12, the Pac 12, and the Southeastern Conference (SEC).⁸ The remaining conferences in the Football Bowl Subdivision of Division I are referred to as the “Group of Five” which includes the American Athletic Conference (AAC), Conference USA (C-USA), the Mid-American Conference (MAC), the Mountain West Conference (MW), and the Sun Belt Conference.⁹ This, in turn, hurts the school’s strength of schedule because their competition

¹ See Zac Al-Khateeb, *Four Years Later, College Football Playoff has Solved no Controversy from BCS Era*, SPORTING NEWS (Dec. 4, 2017), <http://www.sportingnews.com/us/ncaa-football/news/college-football-playoff-controversy-vs-bcs-era-alabama-ohio-state-conference-champions/1n3costjh2wbq16y2s85i2uh8o>.

² See *2017 College Football Rankings- Postseason*, ESPN, http://www.espn.com/college-football/rankings/_/week/1/year/2017/seasontype/3 (last visited Sept. 23, 2018).

³ *Id.*

⁴ See Joe Posnanski, *After Undefeated Season, Why Can’t Boise State be National Champion?*, SPORTS ILLUSTRATED (Jan. 05, 2010), <https://www.si.com/more-sports/2010/01/05/fiesta-bowl>.

⁵ Al-Khateeb, *supra* note 1.

⁶ Bill Bender, *Power 5 vs. Group of 5*, SPORTING NEWS, <http://www.sportingnews.com/us/ncaa-football/news/power-5-conferences-autonomy-ncaa-group-of-5-nick-saban-mike-slive-division-iv-split/1151s8k6rrjvi1gph46mditvr8> (last updated Dec. 29, 2016).

⁷ *Id.*

⁸ *Id.*

⁹ *Id.*

is weaker throughout the year.¹⁰ Even as UCF went undefeated during the season, it did not matter because they played against weaker competitors than the powerhouses of college football. This does not seem right to many people, prompting the arguments each year. The team is punished for lacking conference prestige which is out of their control as conference realignment in the major conferences does not happen often.¹¹ The team can only win the games they are told to play each year. The format is not fair to smaller schools who want their chance to play against the most successful teams in college football. This article proposes an interesting solution for this problem centered around the restructuring of college football into a promotion/relegation system.

In short, the promotion/relegation system is a model used across many soccer leagues around the world.¹² Teams transfer between divisions and leagues based on their performance in the previous season.¹³ Many countries have multiple leagues for clubs to jump back and forth between. The United States is one of the countries that has never used this type of model for any sport; including the Major League Soccer (MLS).¹⁴

This would add to the United States' standard sports model by having dominant, big market teams threatened with the possibility of dropping to a lower division following a bad season. On the other hand, the reverse could also happen with a less prominent team rising through the divisions to compete in the championship of the top league.

This article will breakdown both of these possibilities. In addition, it will explain and illustrate how this format could work in college football,

¹⁰ Matt Baker, *Strength of Schedule an Issue for Group of Five Teams*, TAMPA BAY TIMES (Jan. 2, 2018, 4:00 PM), https://www.tampabay.com/sports/college/Like-it-or-not-strength-of-schedule-an-issue-for-Group-of-Five-teams_164131647.

¹¹ See generally Greg Wallace, *College Football Realignment Moves That Need to Happen*, BLEACHER REPORT (May 7, 2017), <https://bleacherreport.com/articles/2708353-college-football-realignment-moves-that-need-to-happen#slide0>.

¹² See Mike Steere, *Explainer: How relegation works*, CNN (May 18, 2009), <http://edition.cnn.com/2009/SPORT/football/05/18/relegation.explainer/index.html>.

¹³ *Id.*

¹⁴ See J.S., *Why is there no promotion and relegation in the United States?*, THE ECONOMIST (Nov. 23, 2016), <https://www.economist.com/blogs/gametheory/2016/11/football-pyramid-america>.

discuss advantages and disadvantages, and give context using examples of how the model has brought success to different parts of the world.

The goal is to open the conversation to a new way of thinking. It is to bring in a possible new solution for this age-old problem of conference hierarchy that no one wants to change. The best teams should play with the best teams no matter the market size or the alumni contributions. Under this system, anything can happen.

II. HISTORY AND EXPLANATION OF THE ENGLISH FOOTBALL SYSTEM

Before describing how the promotion/relegation system would work with college football, it is important to understand how the system works in soccer today. This article will only refer to the English Football system. There are many leagues throughout the world but all have similar formats.

A. *The Structure*

The English Football system is set up as a nine-level pyramid.¹⁵ The top five levels are the called “The League” and have one league for each level.¹⁶ Levels six through nine are a bit more complex and have multiple leagues and sections within each level.¹⁷ Because of this, the focus of this explanation only focuses on the top five levels. The idea to restructure college football in this manner works best with the simplistic nature of the five-level setup.

The top level of the English Football system is the Premier League.¹⁸ This is the league most familiar and popular throughout the world, featuring teams such as Manchester United, Chelsea, and Liverpool.¹⁹ The next league down (second level) is the League Championship which has teams who may have played in the Premier League recently such as Aston Villa and Stoke City.²⁰ The next three leagues below the League Championship

¹⁵ See Paul Gerald, *A Guide to the Leagues and Cups of English Football*, ENGLISH SOCCER GUIDE, Dec. 25, 2017, <http://englishsoccerguide.com/guide-leagues-cups-english-football/>.

¹⁶ *Id.*

¹⁷ *Id.*

¹⁸ *Id.*

¹⁹ See *Teams*, BBC, <https://www.bbc.com/sport/football/teams> (last visited Oct. 15, 2018).

²⁰ *Id.*

are League One (third level), League Two (fourth level), and the National League (fifth level).²¹

The key thing to remember while thinking about these leagues and levels is how they are all interconnected. If two teams are relegated for poor performance, two teams from the league below are promoted to take their place. With that in mind, each league has a set number of teams that are promoted and relegated each season. For example, the League Championship has three teams that are promoted to the Premier League each year and three teams that are relegated to League One each year.²² It does not have to be an equal number of teams moving leagues for each, but it does have to be equal with the other leagues the teams are being sent to. Consequently, the Premier League would be relegating three teams and League One would be promoting three teams to the League Championship.²³ Leagues must keep the same number of teams each year.²⁴

To better visualize this concept with American teams, if this process was applied to baseball standings, in 2017 the Detroit Tigers and the San Francisco Giants were the worst two teams in the major leagues.²⁵ With the promotion/relegation system, these two teams would fall to the lower Triple-A league and be replaced with the Memphis Redbirds and the Oklahoma City Dodgers which were the two best teams in Triple-A in 2017.²⁶

B. The Points System

Switching back to the English Football system, another unique aspect of this style is the way in which a champion is determined. The Premier League is the only league in this system that has a champion with no upward mobility attached for following season.²⁷ For the Premier League, there is no playoff round to see who becomes the champion as is

²¹ *Id.*

²² Gerald, *supra* note 15.

²³ *Id.*

²⁴ *Id.*

²⁵ See *Standings*, MLB ONLINE, <http://mlb.mlb.com/mlb/standings/index.jsp#20171001> (last visited Oct. 31, 2018).

²⁶ See *Standings*, MLB ONLINE, <http://www.milb.com/standings/index.jsp?lid=117> (last visited Oct. 31, 2018).

²⁷ Although the top four teams do qualify for the Champions League tournament which is Europe's biggest football tournament of the year.

traditional in American sports. As an alternative, a season long contest takes place with each team playing every other team, once at home and once away, to determine the best team.²⁸ The standings are based off a points system, three points for a win, one point for a draw, and the team with the most points at the end of the season wins the championship.²⁹

While this does not appear to be the most exciting way to determine a champion, the English Football system still appreciates a good playoff bracket. For all other leagues using the promotion system, it is not as simple as top three seeds advance. Instead, the first and second place team in the league are locked, but the three through six seeds in the league must compete in a four-team playoff to earn that last spot for promotion.³⁰ The drama of these games are at an all-time high because of the stakes in play. Some of these clubs who are fighting for promotion have a whole English city cheering them on to victory.

Even as that describes the basics of the system, this structure goes throughout all nine levels of the pyramid, with all building off one another. A League Two team could win the Premier League in four years. It is not likely to happen, but the possibility is there. Also, in theory,³¹ a team from the eighth level could move up to the Premier League after earning a promotion each year over a whole decade. The formula thrives off its unpredictability. Even as it is very unlikely, it gives faith to the players, and more importantly the fans, that there is hope to move up to the next league and compete for the championship.

C. *The Valuation of the Leagues*

Another notable feature of the English Football system is the value associated with being promoted or relegated. The discrepancy in the value of the leagues is important to focus on while discussing a comparable college football model. The consulting firm Deloitte calculated that a promotion from League Championship to the Premier League is worth about £120 million of extra revenue for the club.³² The

²⁸ Gerald, *supra* note 15.

²⁹ *Id.*

³⁰ *Id.*

³¹ As alluded to before, the details and team placements become a bit messier in regard to the lower four levels. Nonetheless, teams can find a vertical move up for playing well.

³² See Collins, Paul, *Hull set for 120m pound cash windfall if they win promotion to Premier League*, DAILY MAIL ONLINE (April 26, 2013, 9:08 AM),

buying and selling of player rights is the crux of English football, which does not have a cap limit in place. The closing weeks of the season and the four-team promotion playoff creates incredible drama regarding what is at stake for these clubs. If a club, and the city of supporters, can make this jump, it will pay dividends well beyond the game itself.

The first five levels of the promotion/relegation system are mostly straightforward. It is a system that American sports has not yet accepted because of the owner's voice in all of the decisions. Even if there were multiple leagues of American football, the owner of the Cleveland Browns, Jimmy Haslam, would never vote to approve this system. His team would lose out on millions of dollars after the Browns were relegated out of the National Football League. Outweighing this disapproval is the fact that the drama surrounding each season would be extraordinary and the city/team pride would be brought to another level. This system needs to have some place in American sports.

III. HOW THIS CHANGE WOULD AFFECT COLLEGE FOOTBALL

The way most professional sports in the U.S. are currently set up does not fit well with a promotion/relegation model, even outside of the owner's influence on this matter. The MLS is one of only a few American sports that could change their structure into this model. It is not feasible for American football or for basketball. With baseball and hockey, the multiple league structure is there, but it gets complicated with player rights and the main team owning their minor league affiliate.³³ With most professional options thrown out, the collegiate structure could adapt to this type of change. It has the tiers of divisions already in place and all of the players are only committed to one team. The NCAA should be open to this type of shake up. As previously alluded to, the NCAA's structure has faced some criticism, so seemingly any type of change could be good for their image.

<http://www.dailymail.co.uk/sport/football/article-2315255/Hull-set-make-extra-120m-win-promotion-Premier-League.html>.

³³ When the Boston Red Sox draft a player, they have the option of keeping him in the minor leagues while still owning his rights. He can play on their Triple-A team in Pawtucket, Rhode Island which is still owned by the Red Sox. In contrast, most lower league English football clubs are self-sufficient which makes jumping up and down divisions easier to deal with. Baseball could not have the Boston Red Sox and Pawtucket Red Sox playing in the same league.

Currently, the NCAA has a structure of four major divisions of college football. The four divisions are: the Football Bowl Subdivision (FBS), the Football Championship Subdivision (FCS), Division II, and Division III.³⁴ However, the only mobility schools have between divisions is if conferences are added or if an existing conference adds teams. This does not happen often, nor does it happen with many schools at once. The last time it took place was in the summer of 2017 when the Coastal Carolina Chanticleers jumped from FCS to FBS.³⁵ They were inserted into the Sun Belt Conference and have no plans to leave the FBS level.³⁶

The biggest discrepancy with the English Football system is that college football has conferences within the division. In contrast, all 20 teams in the Premier League are grouped together with no separation between them, which is also true with the other leagues. In college football, multiple conferences make up all four divisions because it better cuts the teams down into a smaller number for each conference. Since college football only has twelve regular season games a year, the conferences help with scheduling purposes as well.

The new college football model would relatively build off what is already in place with only a few major changes. The goal is to replicate the pyramid structure of the English Football system. It would require breaking up all divisions and making them all smaller, so mobility is easier. Right now, there are 130 teams in the FBS, 124 in FCS, 169 in Division II, and 249 in Division III, for a total of 672 teams.³⁷ Comparatively, the first five levels of the English Football system have 116 clubs, and levels one through nine have 687 clubs involved.³⁸ With the large numbers of teams involved in Division II and Division III, these two divisions will be left off for simplicity.³⁹

³⁴ See *College Football Conferences*, ESPN, <http://www.espn.com/college-football/conferences> (last visited Oct. 22, 2018).

³⁵ See Patterson, Chip, *Coastal Carolina's move to Sun Belt will result in 130 FBS teams for 2017*, CBS SPORTS, (September 1, 2015) , <https://www.cbssports.com/college-football/news/coastal-carolinas-move-to-sun-belt-will-result-in-130-fbs-teams-for-2017/>.

³⁶ *Id.*

³⁷ See *supra* note 34.

³⁸ See Gerald, *supra* note 15.

³⁹ If the NCAA is serious about this, they can administer a similar structuring of levels six through nine which are quite complex. A good way of thinking about it is the same pyramid model which an extra wide base at the bottom.

A. Division Realignment

The first major change is to restructure all divisions. The FBS and FCS would be wiped away completely and instead, would be formed into 5 divisions. The first two divisions would be the teams in the “Power Five” conferences (Division I) and the “Group of Five” conference (Division II). The next three divisions would all come from the thirteen conferences in the current FCS. Division III would be made up of the Colonial Athletic Association (CCA), the Missouri Valley Football Conference (MVC), the Ohio Valley Conference (OVC), the Patriot League, and the Southern Conference. Division IV would have the Big Sky, the Mid-Eastern Athletic Conference (MEAC), the Northeast Conference, and the Southland Conference. Finally, Division V includes the Big South, the Ivy League, the Pioneer Football Conference, and the Southwestern Athletic Conference (SWAC). One thing to note is that the schools that are currently independents would be required to join a conference. The chart below illustrates the new changes with the number of teams in parentheses.

Division I (65)	Division II (65)	Division III (47)	Division IV (42)	Division V (35)
ACC (15) ⁴⁰	AAC (14) ⁴¹	CCA (12)	Big Sky (13)	Big South (6)
Big 12 (10)	C-USA (14)	MVC (10)	MEAC (11)	Ivy League (8)
Big Ten (14)	MAC (12)	OVC (9)	Northeast (7)	Pioneer (11)
Pac-12 (12)	MW (13) ⁴²	Patriot League (7)	Southland (11)	SWAC (10)
SEC (14)	Sun Belt (12)	Southern (9)		

⁴⁰ Notre Dame was grouped with the ACC.

⁴¹ Army and Massachusetts were grouped with the AAC.

⁴² BYU was grouped with the MW.

B. Conferences

With this new structure, there are two options to approach the conferences. The first option is that the conferences do not change at all. It will keep the teams in order and continue to help with scheduling. Since there are so many teams still in each division, geographical problems could arise with traveling across country. Keeping the conferences helps to alleviate the geographic difficulties. The only major difference is the conferences will change constantly. The number of teams in each conference will change each year, which could hurt the concept “conference pride.” A downside is the number of teams in Division I and II will be top heavy compared to the other divisions with 65 teams each. It is unfortunately unavoidable with the goal of keeping the conferences intact.

The second option is to start from scratch and do a major overhaul of all the teams and their conferences. This option would lead to more chaos. It would change the landscape of all of college football, but it may be necessary for this to work. All of the divisions would have a similar number of teams even with the possibility of adding more divisions to spread the teams out further. Most leagues around the world have anywhere from 20-30 teams in each level. That number is where this model could thrive and promote incredible drama year to year.

Regardless of the option that is picked, conference pride will be at the forefront of the debate. Fan bases love their conference pride, and anything that appears to take that away from them will cause an uproar. The system will be sustainable with either option as both have their positives and negatives. It all comes down to how much the NCAA wants to rock the boat. For purposes of this article, the first option will be chosen, and conferences will still be intact.

C. Promotion/Relegation

Now that the divisions for the pyramid structure are in place, it is now time to see how this system would work each year. The number of teams that will be promoted and relegated in each division each year will need to be selected. As seen with the English Football system, that number corresponds with the other leagues to maintain the same number of teams in each league per year. In the new structure of college, the number of teams promoted and relegated across the divisions will be five. For example, after each year, five teams will be relegated from Division I

down to Division II and five teams will be promoted from Division II up to Division I.

This new structure will also adopt the promotion playoff that was described with English football. The playoff will only apply to the teams moving up into the division above them. After the season is over, the one through four seeds will be locks to be promoted, but the fifth seed will have to fight their way in. The setup would be a four-team playoff with the fifth seed playing the eighth seed and the sixth seed playing the seventh seed with the winners playing each other for promotion. The stakes would be at an all-time level. Similar to English football, rising into Division I would be a huge payday for the school.

Another aspect to note is the change of conference that will be necessary when these teams rise or fall throughout the system. Each team will need a new conference in their new division. This could be a major drawback of the system, but there is no other option if the conferences are kept. For instance, UCF, being currently in the AAC, would have been promoted based on last season's performance. The question would then become what conference in Division I would UCF join. The answer would be how the conferences are set up by geography. UCF, located in Orlando, Florida, would be eligible for the SEC or ACC. On the other hand, Oregon State, part of the Pac-12, would have been one of the teams relegated this past season, so next year they would be joining the Mountain West.⁴³ Choosing a conference for a team would be a very difficult task because of everything at stake with this decision. A committee, similar to the current one used for the rankings, could be responsible for all these decisions.

D. Determining a Champion

The biggest downside to the English Football system is the way they determine the champion of their leagues. The clubs play 38 games to avoid a playoff of any kind. Occasionally, the league comes down to the last day, but more times than not, the eventual champions have been leading the league for most of the season, and the last five or so matches

⁴³ Another idea that has been floated out there by SB Nation's Bill Connelly is to have all the conferences linked with each level. In other words, each conference would be tied to another conference in the level above. AAC is tied to the ACC, Sun Belt is tied to the SEC, etc. <https://www.sbnation.com/college-football/2017/6/6/15724156/college-football-relegation-promotion-simulation>

hardly even matter to determine the champion. This feature would not be adopted in this new college football system.

In the new structure, all post-season competitions including conference championships, bowl games, and the College Football Playoff are the same. The College Football Playoff will still be the pinnacle of the season for all teams. Of course, only Division I teams qualify, but this is how the current NCAA structure has worked out most of the time. Bowl season, with all the sponsorships and TV deals, will stay untouched through all of this. Finally, even with the conferences ever-changing, conference championships can still go on in the same format. The best two teams would still face off for a conference title before the playoffs. It is crucial to keep some semblance of the old version of college football.

Importantly to some, the ranking system would be a vital part for how this whole system operates. It has been a major concern throughout the years to find the best way to rank the teams. For the new version of college football, there are another two choices. Option one is the process that is currently in use. It is the ranking system that uses a committee to rank the Top 25 each week and for the playoffs. The major difference is that their duties will have to expand to also rank the Top 25 of every other division as well. In addition, the committee will have to rank a Bottom 10 for every division, which may be the toughest task yet. This ranking will directly affect who is promoted each year and has major consequences.

The other option is to use a version that is similar to the English system. This option contains a system that compares records at the end of the season. There, of course, would be multiple teams with the same record. The English settle tie breakers by goal differential throughout the season. College football would use point differential. The main drawback of this system is a problem the NCAA sees today. Some teams have easier schedules than others, and that will still be the case even with the conferences condensed. In English football, teams play each other twice, eliminating any controversy. Even with the problems it may raise, fans may find it thrilling to watch a team run up the score for the purpose of improving point differential, or how fascinating the league would be on the last weekend, watching a team plan around this tie breaker to make the playoff or avoid relegation. It could bring a whole new element to the game.

That being said, the primary issue that matters is finding a ranking system that works and that is fair to all teams. In this system, teams could never have one bad year. Their one bad season could cost them a place in Division I, even only for a year. It would add an intriguing wrinkle to the season. Every game that the bottom teams play will mean so much more than they previously did. Similar to the Premier League, the value of the jump from Division II to Division I in this system would be a huge reward for a great season.

E. Scheduling

Formation of this new structure of college football requires scrapping the four major divisions; however, it is not necessary to lose the conferences. The conferences will still be used for scheduling purposes. On account of there being too many teams for everyone to play twice, this format may not flow the same as English football, in which it is much easier to play 38 games a year having a home and away series with each team. This just is not possible for the “student-athletes” who have classes throughout the week. Plus, American football is not a sport designed for 38 games each year. While it may not go along with their system exactly, tweaks have been made to perfect it as best as possible.

The new scheduling process will be similar to what is employed currently. However, each team must schedule teams within its same division. Each schedule will still feature twelve games of regular season,⁴⁴ conference games, and strong nonconference play. Several basic changes must be made in order for this process to work. First, teams will no longer be able to schedule smaller schools for “warm-up games.” The scheduling will be much more focused on matching teams with similar skill levels. This will keep the strength of schedule for all teams around the same level. Second, scheduling will not occur until the spring or summer before the season because the movement between divisions will not be determined until after the promotions and relegations each season, so teams will not know who is in their division or conference until the dust has settled from the previous year. College football is known for scheduling games years in advance, but most professional leagues in American sports release the schedules in the offseason immediately before the regular season begins. As a result, the scheduling between

⁴⁴ This number could change to thirteen regular season games depending on post-season success.

intraconference divisions would not be essential anymore. With the fluctuation of teams amongst divisions, the divisions themselves may not be able to hold up after a few years. The scheduling will reflect that as it is best to think geographically for ease in travel.

Nothing will change about the physical strain on athletes. The only tangible change in responsibility is that schools and athletic administrations will have to put together a new schedule each year, though it will also allow them to make it an event when they reveal the schedules as we see now with the NFL. The new scheduling process will keep fan bases locked in to games throughout the year because teams will not be playing against far inferior teams from different divisions.

The success of making such drastic changes requires scrapping the old way of thinking about college football matchups. The proposed promotion/relegation system would not change how the game of college football is actually played. The potential issue with the teams that have great seasons but are ignored for a chance at the national championship. It also affects the teams who struggle each year without major penalty of dropping out of the FBS or FCS. With this system, all of these issues could change for the better.

IV. ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF THE PROPOSED SYSTEM

College football involves a massive amount of details. Not all of these details will be addressed in this article. The system in no way can cover every thought people will have in response to this. As a result, many aspects were not discussed in the explanation and breakdown of how the system works. It is important to lay out the advantages and disadvantages of how this restructuring will change the game.

A. Advantages

One of the best parts about this system is the parity it would deliver for the smaller schools. The historic bluebloods have dominated college football for decades. The new structure would give smaller schools a chance to play with the big teams, as seen above in the UCF scenario. Another example is with North Dakota State (NDSU) located in Fargo, North Dakota. NDSU is an FCS school that deserves the chance to play at the highest level. The NDSU Bison have won six of the past seven FCS

Championships.⁴⁵ Not only do they have one of the most dominant football programs in the FCS, they have a rabid fanbase as well. In fact, College Gameday has visited Fargo multiple times in the past few years.⁴⁶ Opportunities for NDSU to play the best teams in college football are not available in the current system. FBS National Championship hopes are restrictive to teams such as NDSU, who have no other choice but to play, and beat, the teams they are scheduled against in a weaker conference or division. The new system gives these teams the opportunity to play teams that are more competitive, allowing them to prove that they belong in the national championship conversation.

Along these lines is the concept of team pride and school spirit increasing tremendously with these new opportunities. Fanbases that have never had a shot at a national title will now have their chance to cheer on their team. As mentioned in the context of NDSU, the team pride that Fargo has for North Dakota State University is at an all-time high and they are not the only small school in that position. The new structure could give even more to cheer about. Even if the school is in Division III to start, there is still technically a possibility they could move up over the course of a few years. Plus, in this new system, it is not national championship or nothing. These teams and fan bases can have smaller goals and reasonable expectations to just be promoted for a certain year. It will bring more opportunities for fans to get behind their teams.

In English football, fan bases are just as passionate, or possibly more so, as the die-hard fans of college football. The stakes these fans bring to each game when their team is facing either promotion or relegation is remarkable. For example, last year, Huddersfield won the League Championship four-team playoff.⁴⁷ The championship match was 120 minutes of nerve-wracking football that came down to a penalty shootout to see which team would move on to the Premier League.⁴⁸ The scene

⁴⁵ See *In epic title game, North Dakota State edges James Madison to win back FCS throne*, ESPN (Jan. 6, 2018), http://www.espn.com/college-football/story/_/id/21985266/north-dakota-state-edges-james-madison-win-fcs-championship.

⁴⁶ See *ESPN College GameDay comes to North Dakota State*, USATODAY (Sept. 17, 2013), <https://www.usatoday.com/story/sports/ncaaf/2013/09/17/north-dakota-state-espn-college-gameday-fargo-theatre/2829479/>.

⁴⁷ See Ian Woodcock, *Huddersfield 0, Reading 0. Huddersfield Town win 4-3 on penalties*, BBC (May 29, 2017), <https://www.bbc.com/sport/football/39995791>.

⁴⁸ *Id.*

was absolutely electric. This is what this new structure of college football could bring to schools across the country.

Even if these clubs have no realistic shot at taking down the top clubs in England, fans still relish the moment in the hopes of being promoted. Rivalries also take the game to another level with pure hatred for a close intown club.⁴⁹ These rivalries formed within each league in previous decades. College football already has some bad blood within its ranks, but adding a chance for promotion would bring it to a whole new level. Promotion means everything to the English, and with a system of multiple championships and playoffs at each level, college football could tap into the passion that it lacks among the smaller schools who do not have a shot at competing.

Another advantage to this system is the thrill of the unknown. The promotion/relegation system has never been brought to the United States before. There has not been a need to think of better ways to improve it for American sports. In applying the system to college football, people will have the opportunity to tweak the way it is implemented to get peak performance, and top dollar, out of it. The NCAA could use this breath of fresh air to avoid scrutiny, and bring peoples' ideas together in an innovative new model that has never been seen before.

For the teams themselves, restructuring would shake some programs to their core demanding each team to have renewed urgency to compete instead of settling for last in the conference each year. These teams will have a new threat of relegation which will affect their annual revenue each season. School administrators will have to put more thought into their football programs. Top teams would likely stay the same, which is significant because the bulk of money in college football comes from these programs and these primetime games. That money will not be adjusted or diminished with this new system.

Admittedly, a small quirk of this system is that demotions could be used as a punishment for infractions. This could be turned into a positive for the NCAA to have another harsh punishment to use. A team that committed a certain level of NCAA violation could be subject to a

⁴⁹ See Nick Miller, *Premier League rivalries unraveled: a history of English football derbies*, THE GUARDIAN, July 11, 2016, <https://www.theguardian.com/sport/2016/jul/12/premier-league-rivalries-unravelling-a-history-of-english-football-derbies>.

demotion to a lower division. This large of a penalty would be felt much more than vacating awards or taking away scholarships.

The idea originated from Italy's Serie A. In 2006, the highest level in Italian football uncovered a scandal involving a network of club managers and referees rigging games by selecting favorable referees to officiate their matches.⁵⁰ The league called for the three clubs, including the league champion Juventus, to be forcefully demoted to Serie B, the league below.⁵¹ The scandal was the first time that a team was demoted because of a punishment in league history.⁵² Even though these circumstances are completely different from college football, there have been instances where a punishment this severe was needed, especially in the recruiting realm. This penalty may not be used all the time, but the option is there if the NCAA needs to resort to it.

These foregoing lists only a few of the many advantages of the proposed system. The real impact would come from the new pride the players and fans could take on with the joys of promotion and the threat of relegation. It means just a little bit more for the teams who normally play meaningless games in December.

B. Disadvantages

Any promotion/relegation system proposal will have some serious blowback. While the idea seems great in theory, criticism is inevitable. There are many rich, influential people who want things to stay as they are. The biggest dilemma with the whole system is making the change worth it for the schools and administrators. Each disadvantage can be traced back to one thing—money.

One of the hardest things to predict is how the existing revenue streams would react to a change like this. Billions of dollars are put into college football across all current divisions, considering all the money from sponsorships, TV deals, and the like. It is a huge beast, but money oftentimes is the biggest factor behind any decision made.

⁵⁰ See Clayton, Lee, *Juve, Lazio and Fiorentina relegated*, DAILY MAIL ONLINE, <http://www.dailymail.co.uk/sport/football/article-395629/Juve-Lazio-Fiorentina-relegated.html>. (last visited Oct. 21, 2018).

⁵¹ *Id.*

⁵² *Id.*

The first disadvantage is that the system puts all the money into the top level of play. Currently, this top level is made up of 130 FBS schools, but with the new system it would be cutting that number in half. Middle to end-of-the-pack schools may not be satisfied with being split up in smaller divisions. For example, the discrepancy between the Premier League and the League Championship is stark. So, the question then becomes what will divisions one through five be worth, and is that disparity between divisions too much for the schools? If the new divisions do not make profitability from the league as valuable or more valuable, schools may not be interested.

Granted, this may be how the system is working already. In 2017, The Wall Street Journal published a report that ranked college football programs on value alone.⁵³ It showed that, outside the independents Notre Dame and BYU, the top sixty most valuable programs were all in a “Power Five” conference.⁵⁴ The first “Group of Five” program to be listed was UCF at number sixty-one overall.⁵⁵ These numbers paint a clear picture; all the money is in the “Power Five” already. The lower conferences do not have much of an economic impact to the landscape of college football. Splitting the two groups into their own divisions may not make much of a difference that is not already prominent. It may actually incentivize teams to aim for Division I, thereby increasing the programs’ values.

The next disadvantage of this system is yearly conference realignments. Teams moving in and out of the conference poses a challenge to TV deals and revenue shares amongst the conferences each year. If a conference were to add another team, the conference’s existing schools will have their shares cut. Schools would not be happy about that change. Or, in the extreme, what if four teams were promoted which were all southeastern schools? Then, the current schools in the SEC would presumably have to split the revenues with four more schools.

Additionally, the committee choosing which conference the new team goes to may cause problems. Even if the simple solution is assignment based on geography, problems would still arise regarding time. For

⁵³ See Ryan Brewer, *College Football Value Rankings*, WALL ST. J., https://graphics.wsj.com/table/COUNT_09212017. (last visited Oct. 21, 2018).

⁵⁴ *Id.*

⁵⁵ *Id.*

example, if UCF entered into the SEC, and Western Michigan were promoted to the Big 10, the SEC would have to deal with gaining a better team in their conference while the other conference received a weaker team. Both of these dilemmas are smaller problems in the grand scheme, and they could be ironed out over time once the system was put in place.

Finally, the last disadvantage to explore is the simple fact that this system may not change anything for the better. The argument could be made that while this system would most definitely change the structure, Alabama and Clemson could still win every year. In other words, the top teams could still run college football and nothing might be able to stop that from happening. On top of that, these top schools may be aided by the new scheduling rules. There would be an incentive for teams to schedule weaker competition since that would now be in their control

All in all, the disadvantages boil down to whether the money will continue to come in for these schools as it had before. Some schools may miss out on certain benefits they receive now if they fall down to Division II. That will not be feasible for many administrations making the decisions.

V. CONCLUSION

Eventually, the NCAA will have to address the yearly concerns about the mid-majors and “Group of Five” schools that never make the playoffs. The committee’s answer that these schools do not play tough enough competition should not work anymore under the system proposed in this article. These schools cannot do much about who they play if they beat their conference competition on a regular basis. It is impossible for these teams to get a seat at the table when everyone looks down on them from the start. This promotion/relegation system would help give all teams a way to play against the best the college football has to offer, and to get there by earning the spot.

If the NCAA were to implement on this system in college football, it would change the way of thinking about the game as a whole. Each season would bring in more drama than other seasons in the past. The skeleton of the old model would still be in place with the blueblood programs on top, but there would likely be some new faces competing. The teams that have been profiting off of being “bottom of the barrel” for years would be in jeopardy of losing their “Power Five” (Division I)

status. It could put programs with real administrative decisions to make which could give the fans a better product.

There are many questions that are still left unanswered with this system, and it will take many opinions and voices to perfect it before it can be implemented. But the concept is there, along with and the potential for even greater passion and pride in fan bases than ever before. The NCAA can break out of its mold and try something new and exciting. Under this system, anything can happen.

